

WEEK 8:

MUSIC AND THE ENVIRONMENT

By Elodie, Nathan, Olivia and Emma

INTRO

READING ONE

DECOMPOSED: A POLITICAL ECOLOGY OF MUSIC

BY KYLE DEVINE

Main Argument:

- Music is not immaterial, its deeply tied to resource extraction, manufacturing, and waste.
 - Recording history shows hidden global material networks behind music.
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Shellac Era 78 RPM records, early 1900s:

- Made from Shellac resin and quarried minerals
- Embedded in colonial trade systems and early globalization.
- Environmental damage from forest use and and mining.

Vinyl & Plastic Era (post-WWII):

- PVC records tied music production to the oil industry.
- LPS gained cultural value and longevity but were toxic and hard to recycle.
- CDs expanded petrochemical use and added to waste streams.





Shellac (1900–1950) → Plastic
(1950–2000) → Data (2000–present)

Digital Music and Streaming:

Marketed as “dematerialised” but relies on:

- Energy- heavy data centers and server farms.
- Short-lived electronics (phones, laptops, headphones).

Global inequality & E-waste:

- 70–80% of Global North’s e-waste exported to the Global South.
- India & Kenya show vibrant mobile-first music cultures, but also bear e-waste burdens.
- Recycling industries trace music’s shift: records - CDs - computers - e-waste.

KEY TERMS / CONCEPTS / THEMES

Political ecology: links between environmental change, power, and socio-economic systems applied here to music's material lifeworlds.

Preservation paradox (after Sterne): recording promises permanence yet accelerates turnover/obsolescence.

Material flows / topology: follow the stuff (resins, minerals, oil, data centers, cables) and their afterlives (reuse, landfill, incineration).

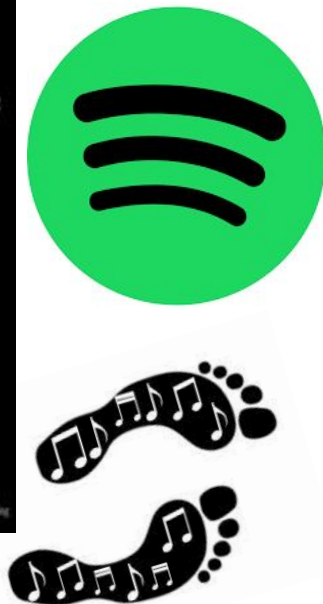
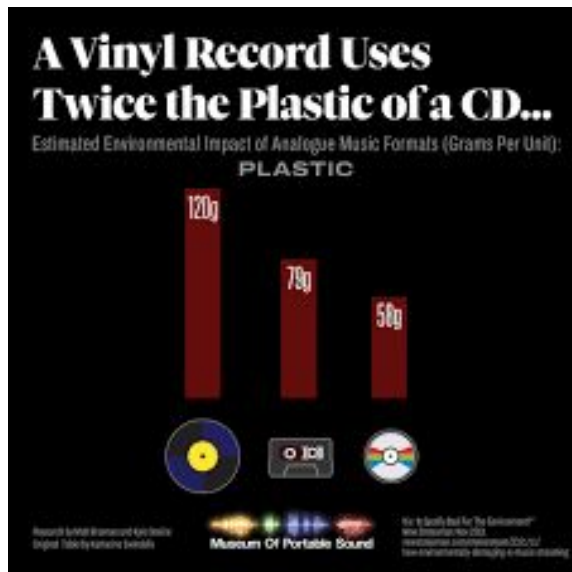
Secondary economies (Straw): aftermarket circulation that keeps formats (e.g., LPs) socially "alive" even when value is "exhausted."

Planned obsolescence: design + fashion cycles that shorten device lifetimes; crucial for the data era's e-waste.

Infrastructural inversion: making hidden pipes (server farms, CDNs, cables, spectrum) visible as cultural determinants.

Dematerialization (myth/claim) vs. rematerialization: digital doesn't abolish matter; it *shifts* it to networks and devices.

SPOTIFY AND THE RISE OF STREAMING PLATFORMS



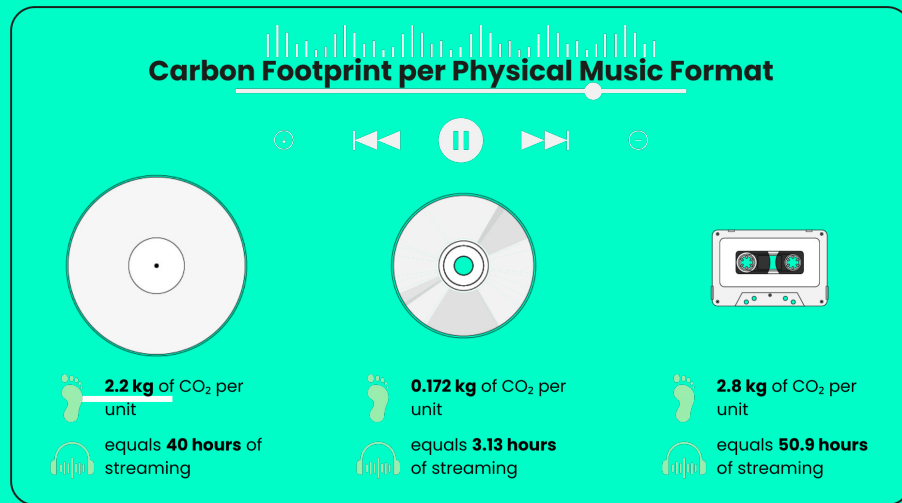
Spotify and streaming platforms illustrate Devine's argument about the myth of dematerialization.

Streaming is often seen as “green” since it eliminates physical products like CDs or vinyl.

Brennan & Devine (2019): CDs in the 2000s produced ~157 million kg of plastic annually in the U.S.; streaming has increased music consumption so much that its carbon footprint may now exceed the CD era.

Platforms like Spotify and Apple Music rely on energy-intensive data centers, cloud servers, and network infrastructure, especially in fossil-fuel-heavy regions.

Music is repeatedly streamed, multiplying emissions over time.



READING TWO: CIVIL DISCObEDIENCE CATHERINE STRONG

- **Key concepts:**

‘bad environmentalism’: environmental thought that employs dissident, often-denigrated affects. In addition to gloom and doom, these include guilt, shame, didacticism, prescriptiveness, sentimentality, reverence, seriousness, sincerity, earnestness, sanctimony, self-righteousness, and wonder – as well as the heteronormativity and whiteness of the movement. and sensibilities to reflect critically on both our current moment and mainstream environmental art, activism, and discourse. bad environmentalism incorporates queer theory – using queerness ‘as a stance rather than an identity’. These include ‘irony, irreverence, perversity, and playfulness but also absurdity, camp, frivolity, indecorum, ambivalence, and glee’ (Strong C, 2020).

Main argument:

Bad environmentalism" uses "dissident affects" such as gaiety, irreverence, and playfulness to create new forms of environmental resistance through popular music.

"Bad Environmentalism" (Nicole Seymour):

Replace "gloom, doom, guilt, shame" with "irony, irreverence, perversity, playfulness"

XR Discobedience: Using "Stayin' Alive" during climate protest in Melbourne 2019.

"Queer Time": Disruption of linear time to create alternative futures

Cultural Memory: Disco's complex cultural associations enable new meanings



Musical example: The Extinction Rebellion group blocked off several intersections in the Melbourne CBD last night as part of their 'disco-bedience' protest, dancing to Staying Alive by the Bee Gees to draw attention to the climate crisis (Liam P, 2019)

Example 1: XR Civil Disobedience

Event Overview:

Climate protests use choreographed dance to "Stayin' Alive" (Bee Gees)

Takes place at public spaces - intersections, CBD streets

Start Melbourne 2019, spread to 20+ countries (Global Disobedience)

Key Lyrics & Reinterpretation:

"Life goin' nowhere, somebody help me" - urban alienation → climate despair

"Stayin' alive, stayin' alive" - personal survival → planetary survival

No explicit environmental content - allows flexible interpretation

Disco's "survival" theme resonates with climate emergency

"Bad Environmentalism" Characteristics:

Joy and creativity instead of doom/gloom messaging

Lowbrow disco culture vs serious environmental discourse

Disruption through pleasure instead of guilt/shame

Cultural memory of 70s hedonism addressing current crisis



Example 2: Solar Power - Lorde

- **Nature vs Technology:** Album emphasizes reconnecting with Mother Earth over modern technology - "throw my cellular device in the water" (AI N 2021)
- **Dual Interpretation:** Described as both "joyful and optimistic" and containing sadness about celebrity culture, climate crisis, and self-doubt (AI N 2021)

Artist's Intent

- Lorde views album as "both a process of grieving and a process of celebration" regarding nature
- Clarifies it's NOT "my big climate change record" (Laura S, 2021)
- Beach imagery will "reveal its mysteries" in future videos

Fan Interpretations

- **Political Commentary:** Solar Power video seen as criticism of:
 - Sun (Lorde in yellow) tricking people into ignoring climate warnings
 - Politicians ignoring environmental problems while people suffer (Laura S, 2021)



Positive Environmental Messaging Through Music (Helen M P, 2022):

- **Evaluative Conditioning:** Pairs upbeat music with sustainable living imagery
- **Brainstem Reflexes:** Upbeat tempo creates excitement
- **Visual Imagery:** Beach/sunshine descriptions create positive nature associations
- **Episodic Memory:** Connects to listeners' fond summer memories

Controversy & Challenge

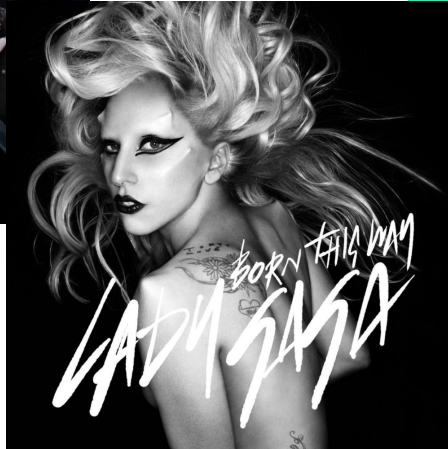
- **Criticism:** Album considered too "light" for climate crisis severity
- **Core Tension:** Balancing positive momentum vs. appropriate seriousness for environmental issues (Helen M P, 2022)

Overall Impact

- Offers "new kind of intimacy" for living more intensely with ourselves, others, and the world (Guest writer, 2021)

READING TWO: KEY POINT DISCUSSION

“Queering” of time



Main Point: XR's Discobedience protest was 'queering time'

- Idea of living in the present not knowing what the future entails
- Challenges and disrupts linear, capitalist, model of time and living life
- The choreographed protest collapsed past (disco's queer subculture), present (protest) and future (climate crisis)

Lady Gaga - 'Born this way' (2011)

- Revival of disco's queer legacy into modern pop
- Queer empowerment anthem challenging heteronormativity
- Collapsed past (also draws on disco's queer history), present (empowering LGBTQ), and future (imagines an inclusive space)
- How music can combine past, present, future together as a form of empowerment + reimagining futures
- Disrupting traditional heteronormative structures – system/mindset of consumer capitalism → climate activism

READING TWO: KEY POINT DISCUSSION

Environmentalism in mainstream music



Main Point: Mainstream music promoting environmentalism perceived as inauthentic

- Mainstream artists releasing eco-songs or promoting/encouraging environmentalism in tours, etc
- Pedelty argues they are directly tied to consumer capitalism → Credibility in question

Lil Dicky - 'Earth' (2019)

- Charity single for donating to environmental causes
- Star-studded features including Justin Bieber, Ariana Grande, Miley Cyrus
- Severe backlash - seen as hypocritical, corporate

Coldplay's Music of the Spheres tour

- Eco-tour aiming to reduce carbon footprint- Renewable energy and powered by fans (kinetic)
- Accused of 'greenwashing', flying on private jets
- Good intentions not enough for mainstream artists
 - Nature of the pop industry makes contradictions inevitable



litter left behind (Picture: Paul Jacobs/pictureexclusive.com)

Music Festivals

Carefree blissfully irresponsible culture.

Consequences created by attendants: Soil erosion, litter, single use accessories.

The average music festival creates 500 tons of co2 over three days.

Offsetting actions is a band-aid solution and does not fix the bigger problem.

<https://www.tiktok.com/@niallwhorahgf/video/7112500504164420910>



Photo: TikTok/@beth.millerr



Photo: Mark Hutchkins

DISCUSSION

1. DEVINE DISCUSSES HOW STREAMING HAS AN ENORMOUS CARBON FOOTPRINT AND IS ENERGY-HEAVY... WHY DO YOU THINK IT'S SEEN AS ENVIRONMENTALLY FRIENDLY?

2. WHO'S MORE RESPONSIBLE FOR THE ENVIRONMENTAL IMPACT OF MUSIC - THE ARTIST, THE LABEL, OR THE INDUSTRY/SYSTEM AS A WHOLE?

3. MANY MUSIC STARS USE THEIR PLATFORMS WITH A WIDE REACH TO PROMOTE ENVIRONMENTALISM...

ARE THEY THE BEST CANDIDATES FOR CLIMATE ACTIVISM?
OR DOES THE PRIVILEGE AND IMAGE OF A POP STAR MAKE IT
BASICALLY POINTLESS?

4. WHAT MUSIC GENRES ARE MOST EFFECTIVE FOR PROTESTS? WHICH TYPES OF MUSIC DO YOU THINK ARE MORE CREDIBLE THAN OTHERS AND WHY?

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